

THE CHAMPION FAMILY MANSIONS

A Study of 18th-Century Masterworks Built by Architect William Spratt

During the post-Revolutionary era of the 1790s, the prominent Champion family of Connecticut commissioned master joiner and architect **William Spratt** (Sprat) to build two of New England's most celebrated Federal and late-Georgian residential landmarks. Spratt, a former British Royal Artillery artificer captured during the Revolutionary War, became one of Connecticut's most influential builders, famed for bringing aristocratic British pattern-book sophistication to Connecticut high society.

Historical Context & Family Connection: Colonel Henry Champion (1723–1797) was the Commissary General who famously organized the critical 1778 cattle drive to George Washington's starving troops at Valley Forge. His sons, General Henry Champion (1751–1836) and General Epaphroditus Champion (1756–1834), were celebrated officers, merchants, and statesmen. Their close family ties to merchant Julius Deming of Litchfield—Spratt's chief patron—led directly to Spratt being engaged to erect both family estates.

1. The Henry Champion House (Colchester, CT)

Location: Westchester Village, Colchester, CT | **Built:** 1790 | **NRHP Ref:** 72001332 (1972)

Commissioned by Colonel Henry Champion as an estate for his son, General Henry Champion, this magnificent Federal period residence stands on Westchester Road at Pickerel Lake Road. It represents one of Spratt's earliest and most creative residential commissions in eastern Connecticut, marrying grand classical detailing with regional vernacular forms.

Distinctive Architectural Features:

- **Rare Hybrid Roof Structure:** A 2½-story wood-frame structure featuring a distinctive *gambrel roof* with three gabled dormers on the front façade, integrated into a rear *saltbox-like slope* descending toward the first floor.
- **Grand Symmetrical Façade:** Five bays wide with two interior brick chimneys rising symmetrically behind the main roof ridge, adorned with elegant dentil moulding along the cornice.
- **Classical Entrance Portico:** A pedimented gabled portico sheltering a formal center doorway flanked by intricate sidelight windows and classical pilasters, complemented by projecting cornices over first-floor windows.
- **Elite Interior Woodwork:** Highly celebrated for its exceptionally narrow 18th-century floorboards (a sign of immense luxury at the time), full vertical-grain raised paneling, lattice arcades, and side pilasters.

2. The Epaphroditus Champion House / "The Terraces" (East Haddam, CT)

Location: Landing Hill Rd / Main St, East Haddam, CT | **Built:** 1794 | **Style:** Late Georgian / Federal

Built for General Epaphroditus Champion—brother of General Henry Champion and brother-in-law to Litchfield merchant Julius Deming—this monumental riverside estate was designed by Spratt to rival the finest country houses in the young republic. Overlooking the Connecticut River, it stands as an architectural icon of 1790s Connecticut and is featured on the cover of the Dover classic *Great Georgian Houses of America*.

Distinctive Architectural Features:

- **Monumental Stone Terracing:** Set on a dramatic bluff, the home is renowned for its series of bold stone terrace retaining walls that step down toward the river, earning it the historic moniker *"The Terraces"*.
- **Refined Mantels & Millwork:** Built by Spratt's seasoned artisan team, the interior showcases some of the most sophisticated late-Georgian fireplace mantels, fluted pilasters, and carved architraves in New England.
- **Substantial Masonry & Basement:** Features full stone flooring throughout the high-ceilinged basement, reflecting high-end commercial and residential craftsmanship.
- **Riverfront Presence:** Oriented to capture commanding views of the Connecticut River trade route, highlighting Epaphroditus Champion's success as an international shipping merchant.

Architectural & Historical Comparison

Attribute	The Henry Champion House	The Epaphroditus Champion House
Location	Colchester (Westchester), CT	East Haddam, CT (Connecticut River)
Year Built	1790	1794
Original Patron	Col. Henry Champion for Gen. Henry Champion	Gen. Epaphroditus Champion (U.S. Congressman)
Primary Architectural Style	Federal with Gambrel/Saltbox vernacular blend	High Late-Georgian / Federal Masterpiece
Signature Exterior Detail	Gambrel roof with 3 dormers & pedimented portico	Massive multi-tier dry-laid stone terraces
Signature Interior Detail	Ultra-narrow floorboards, vertical paneling	Elaborate high-style fireplace mantels & stone floor
National Recognition	National Register of Historic Places (1972)	Cover of <i>Great Georgian Houses of America</i>

Notes for Website Implementation

Recommended Web Content Sections:

1. **Architectural Lineage:** Emphasize William Spratt's connection between Litchfield high-style architecture and the Champion family homes in Colchester and East Haddam.
2. **Preservation Status:** Highlight the 1972 National Register designation (Colchester) and feature historical preservation milestones.
3. **Revolutionary War Pedigree:** Connect the architecture to Colonel Henry Champion and his sons' pivotal logistical and military roles under General George Washington.